

As H. L. Mencken once observed, “the chief value of money lies in the fact that one lives in a world where it is overestimated.” (That was 60 years ago; imagine what he’d say today.) And that’s why I want to leave you with this message: What can be counted and weighed and spent is only a small part of *enough*. To understand what *enough* means in the larger picture of existence, we must all keep in mind the many other things that count in this life, even though (after that sign in Einstein’s office) they can’t be counted.

The idea that money isn’t everything returns us to the Kurt Vonnegut story with which I opened this book. When I finally tracked down the source of the story, it turned out to be a poem, published in the *New Yorker* magazine in 2005. It’s delightful; even better, it’s only 92 words long:

*True story, Word of Honor:
Joseph Heller, an important and funny writer
now dead,
and I were at a party given by a billionaire
on Shelter Island.
I said, “Joe, how does it make you feel
to know that our host only yesterday
may have made more money
than your novel ‘Catch-22’
has earned in its entire history?”
And Joe said, “I’ve got something he can never have.”
And I said, “What on earth could that be, Joe?”
And Joe said, “The knowledge that I’ve got enough.”
Not bad! Rest in Peace!*

Rest in Peace indeed, for both Heller and Vonnegut, who went to his reward early in 2007. These two men brought much laughter into the world, captured many of the ironies of human existence, and punctured many over-inflated egos. But not R.I.P. for the rest of us. There’s too much of the world’s work still to be done, and there are never enough citizens with determined hearts, courageous character, intelligent minds, and idealistic souls to do it.